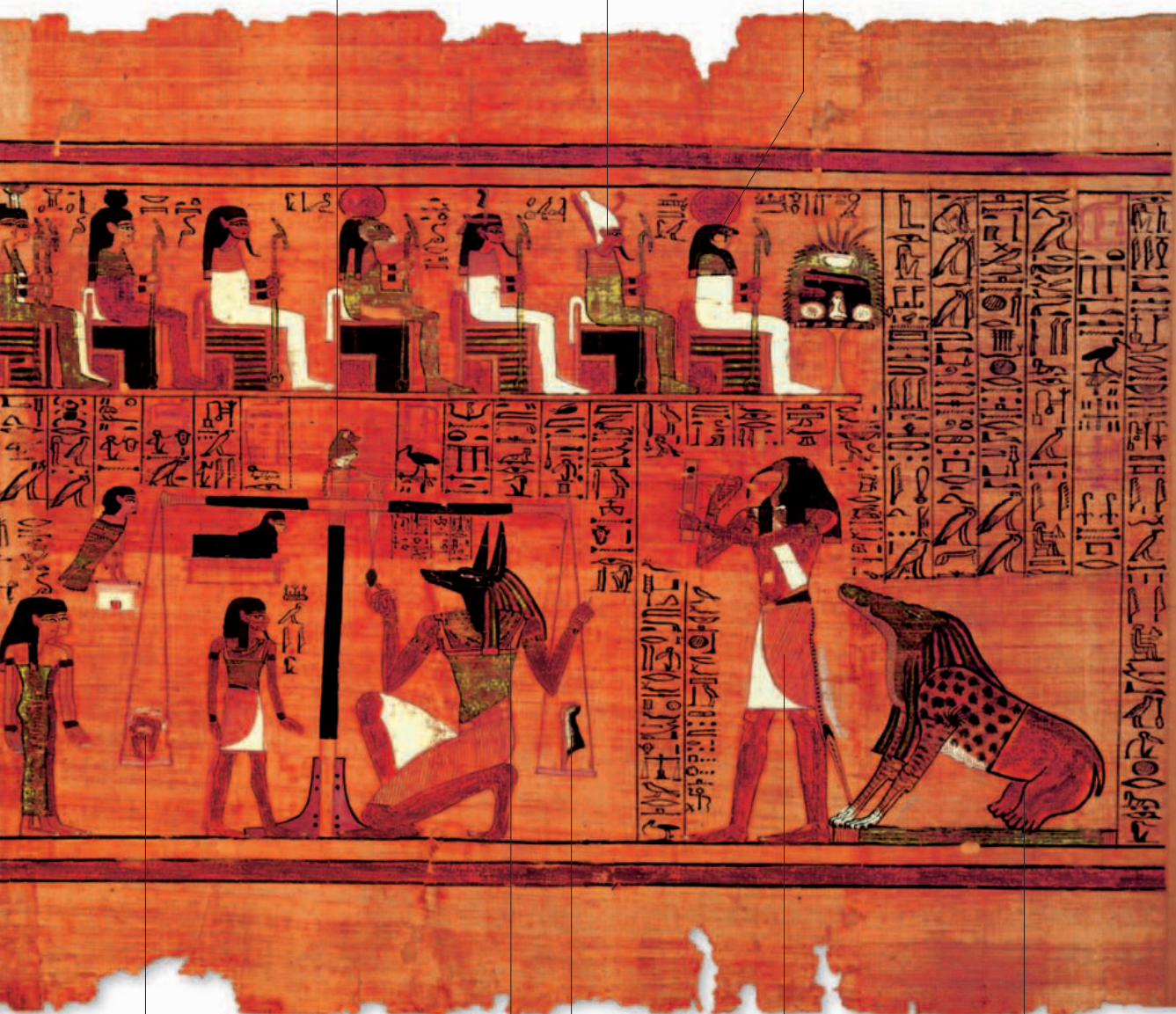


The bird-goddess **Ma'at**, keeper of truth and harmony, daughter of Ra and linked with Thoth, perches symbolically atop the scales of justice.

Osiris, the supreme judge of such ceremonies, sits among the jury of gods. He is wearing the crown of Upper Egypt.

Amun-Ra was an amalgamation of the sun god Ra and the god of the air, Amun. He has a falcon's mask and bears the solar disk on his head.



Any's heart, depicted with the Egyptian hieroglyph for "heart," lies in one pan of the scales of judgment.

The scales are supervised by the jackal-headed Anubis. Considered to be Osiris's son, Anubis was an underworld guide.

The Feather of **Ma'at** lies in the other pan. If the heart weighs the same as the feather, eternal afterlife is assured.

Thoth, chief scribe of the gods, notes the results of the weighing of Any's heart.

Ammit, a strange beast that is part lion, crocodile, and hippopotamus, waits to devour any heart that is found wanting.

able to feed and survive to reach the afterlife. This is why preservation was so important—to keep the "soul" alive after death.

Preserving the body

Embalmers washed the body, preferably in water from the Nile. They then removed the intestines, stomach, liver, and lungs and placed them in four vessels called canopic jars. The brain was removed through the nostrils, but the heart, considered to be the source of intelligence, was left in place. The body was then stuffed with



Organ storage

The removed organs were placed in canopic jars to prevent decay. The jar second from right represents Anubis, the main god of embalming.

linen (to keep its proper shape and appearance) and made whole again. It was soaked with preservative salts, resins, and oils, and decorated with protective charms, called amulets. Those shaped like a scarab beetle were especially potent as the insect's life cycle reflected the daily "rebirth" of the sun. The body was wrapped in linen bandages, placed in a coffin, and buried along with other amulets or items from everyday life to provide comfort in the hereafter.

AFTER

The cult of Osiris survived beyond the ancient Egyptian period, and influenced newly developing belief systems.

CHANGING CULTS

By the Ptolemaic period in Egypt (323–30 BCE) **118–19 >>** the cult of Osiris had begun to fade and the cult of **Serapis** was on the rise. This combined the cults of Osiris and the sacred bull Apis. Serapis was at first identified with Osiris, but then became entirely separate. Cults of Osiris and Isis lived on in various provinces of the Roman Empire **110–13 >>**, with temples to **Isis** built in Roman London and Pompeii.



ROMAN-ERA MUMMY

THE IMPACT OF OSIRIS

Many scholars believe that the ideas surrounding Osiris and his kingdom of the dead influenced the development of the world's major religions **144–147 >>**. The belief in a god's rebirth and the idea that happiness in the next life could be achieved by being good can be reinterpreted as the concepts of **resurrection** and **salvation**. The performance of rites to connect humans with a divine presence is related to the idea of **sacrament**. These ideas are present in a variety of religions, including **Christianity**.

FREEMASONRY

Osiris lives on today within the "secret society" known as the **Freemasons**. Some of their beliefs and symbolism are connected to the figure of Osiris, partly as a way of evoking a sense of order and mystery **rooted in ancient wisdom**.

Osiris sitting in judgment

This papyrus scene, from the *Book of the Dead* of Any (New Kingdom, c. 1550–1069 BCE), shows Osiris deciding Any's destiny in a ceremony believed to take place after death. Any's heart is weighed against the feather of Ma'at, goddess of truth and justice. Bearing instructions on dealing with obstacles in the afterlife, a "book of the dead" was commissioned just before the subject's death, and always showed a favorable judgment.

IDEAS

THE CULT OF ATEN

During the period of Egypt's New Kingdom (c. 1550–1069 BCE), when Osiris worship was at its peak, the 18th-dynasty pharaoh Akhenaten created a breakaway cult of his own. He decided to worship the Sun's disc, in the form of a god called Aten. The cult, which some scholars cite as the first example of the worship of a single god (monotheism), came to an end at the close of Akhenaten's reign, after which the old order returned. This image shows Akhenaten with his chief wife, Nefertiti (see p.65), and one of their daughters (they are known to have had at least six) worshipping the Sun's rays.

